

LAW AND BEHOLD Manoj Bajpayee in Sirf Ek Bandaa Kaafi Hai

Few actors in Hindi cinema have the depth of talent that helps them survive the test of time and the change that comes with it. Manoj Bajpayee, most will agree, belongs in that exclusive league of extraordinary gentlemen. Such is his command over his craft that it feels like an intrinsic part of his being. By his own admission, he may falter with his choices, but Bajpayee the actor for the most part has emerged unblemished. A Bajpayee-starrer comes with the weight of expectation—that it will be a compelling and relevant story. After nearly three decades in front of the camera and winning three National Awards, one wonders: is acting as easy as breathing for the 54-year-old now? Bajpayee begs to differ.

"You have to work every day to make the relationship work," he says. "Just because you love to be in it doesn't mean you can take it for granted and start taking chances with it. I'm aware about how I want to evolve as an actor." In fact, most work days, he adds, tend to be "bad", but the "beauty" lies in the fallibilities. "When it is difficult to crack it, you try hammering it from all angles," he says. "Yes, it is frustrating at times. But it's that journey of searching that I enjoy the most."

For his latest OTT release, *Sirf Ek Bandaa Kaafi Hai* (releasing on ZEE5 on May 23), Bajpayee's journey sees him playing P.C. Solanki, a lawyer who made it his mission to secure justice for a minor who accused the influential godman Asaram Bapu of sexual abuse. Bajpayee met Solanki straight on set, with the idea being to capture his essence without imitation. He identified with Solanki's "stubbornness", an attitude he says has kept him in the running too. "He [Solanki] is relentless," he says. "Once he takes on something, he goes after it and takes it to a positive conclusion."

Interestingly, *Sirf Ek Bandaa Kaafi Hai* is the first time that Bajpayee, who has made a living creating heroes out of ordinary men, plays a lawyer in a film. It was anything but easy. "There are too many lines to memorise and you have to maintain the realism [while doing so]," he says. The climax with its seven pages worth of dialogues posed a challenge. It didn't help that director Apoorv Singh Karki aimed to shoot it in one go. "There was no other option but to rehearse it 150 times. I stopped counting after that," he says. "I couldn't do it justice until then. So yes, [acting] is not as easy as breathing."

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The film also continues Bajpayee's penchant for collaborating with new directors and those who have an indie spirit running through their veins. It has resulted in some career-defining work for the actor in the past decade, including *Aligarh* (Hansal Mehta),